

EKPO

A Feature Screenplay

Working Draft
August 24, 2026

FADE IN:

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - PRE-DAWN

A kettle begins to whistle. MALIK OKU, 36, appears from the pantry in funeral trousers and a white undershirt. He crosses the kitchen before the whistle reaches its full voice. Switches off the burner.

Checks the other three. All cold. The house around him is ready for a man who will not come downstairs. At the entrance: A polished pair of black shoes. A carved walking stick.

Prayer beads looped carefully over the handle. In the living room: ACHEBE beside SOYINKA. An EFIK BIBLE with a repaired spine. Canadian immigration manuals, decades out of date.

A brass leopard on a tray darkened by fingerprints. Family photographs arranged with almost obsessive care. One frame hangs crooked. The only one. In the kitchen: Gari. Crayfish. Maggi. Peak Milk. Ovaltine.

Three mustard jars in the refrigerator door. One thriving plant on the sill. Two dead ones beside it. Malik pours hot water into a mug. Does not drink. He wipes an already-clean section of counter. Stops.

Looks toward the staircase. Nothing there but the pale square of the landing. The front door opens. ADE OKU, 32, enters carrying his dress shoes. His tie hangs around his neck like a surrender flag.

He watches Malik wipe the same place again.

ADE

You know they sell those
pre-cleaned.

MALIK

You said six-thirty.

ADE

I meant emotionally.

Malik checks his watch. 6:41. Then the wall clock. 6:40.

ADE

Vancouver is running behind.

Malik watches the second hand. It hesitates at twelve. Moves. Hesitates again. He takes the clock down and removes the battery. The ticking stops.

ADE

You won.

MALIK

It is broken.

ADE

That has never stopped you
before.

Malik sets the clock face-down. Three coffees wait beside the sink in a straight line. Ade takes the one at the end. Malik moves the remaining two closer together. Ade notices. He opens the refrigerator. Yellow mustard.

Dijon. Grainy. Ade rests his thumb on the grainy lid. Closes the refrigerator without taking anything.

MALIK

You need to change.

ADE

This is black.

MALIK

Those are sweatpants.

ADE

Grief has lowered its standards.

Malik removes a loose thread from Ade's coat sleeve. Ade lets him. The front door opens again. KAI OKU, 25, enters with a digital camera against his chest and noise-cancelling headphones around his neck.

He stops just inside. Listens. The refrigerator hum. Water moving through old pipes. A delivery truck reversing two houses away. The soft scrape of Malik folding a dish towel into exact thirds.

Kai looks toward the face-down clock.

KAI

What happened to it?

MALIK

It loses time.

Kai turns the clock face-up. The missing battery rests beside it.

KAI

One second every minute.

ADE

Dad bought it at a gas station.

KAI

He hated losing time.

MALIK

Then he should have bought a better clock.

Malik picks up his mug. Still does not drink. Near Solomon's chair sits an old CAMCORDER. Scratched casing. A strip of masking tape underneath: SOLOMON. Kai picks it up.

Presses POWER. Nothing. He opens the battery compartment. Empty.

KAI

Where is the battery?

MALIK

Leave it.

KAI

He kept them in the blue drawer.

Kai crosses to a narrow drawer beside the telephone. Opens it. Rubber bands. Receipts. A tiny screwdriver. Three dead pens. No battery. Kai searches beneath the receipts.

MALIK

Kai.

Kai closes the drawer. Then opens it again.

ADE

Maybe it achieved freedom.

Kai keeps searching.

ADE

The battery. Not Dad.

No one laughs. Ade looks down. Kai removes every object from the drawer and arranges them on the counter. Rubber bands together. Pens parallel. Receipts by size. One receipt is folded around something hard.

Kai opens it. A small BRASS CARVING. Worn smooth at the edges. Animal at one angle. Mask at another. Kai turns it beneath the kitchen light.

MALIK

Put it back.

KAI

What is it?

MALIK

Something he kept.

KAI

That is not an answer.

MALIK

It is this morning.

Kai studies Malik. Sets the carving beside the camcorder. Malik returns it to the receipt. Returns the receipt to the drawer. Closes the drawer firmly. Kai crosses to the crooked photograph.

The three brothers as children beside Solomon. Malik rigid in a suit too large for him. Ade caught halfway through saying something. Kai small enough to be held. Solomon looks directly at the camera. Not smiling.

The frame leans slightly left. Kai straightens it. Steps back. The ceiling light washes Solomon's face from the glass. Kai tilts the frame crooked again. Solomon returns.

KAI

He did that on purpose.

MALIK

Did what?

KAI

Left it wrong.

ADE

Maybe he was testing whether
Malik could feel joy.

Malik lifts three garment bags.

MALIK

Get dressed.

Kai remains by the photographs. On a lower shelf, an empty rectangle interrupts a line of dust. Something stood there long enough to leave an outline.

KAI

What is missing?

Malik checks the folder he brought. Funeral programme.
Death certificate. Three printed schedules.

MALIK

Nothing we need today.

KAI

That is not what I asked.

MALIK

We leave in twelve minutes.

ADE

He made an agenda for Dad's
funeral.

MALIK

Someone had to.

ADE

Yeah.

Too fast. Too sharp. Malik looks at him. Ade softens.

ADE

Imagine the chaos otherwise.
People grieving without assigned
seating.

Malik aligns the folder with the counter's edge.

ADE

There he is.

MALIK

Who?

ADE

Nobody.

Ade takes the garment bags from him. For one brief moment, Malik has nothing in his hands. He looks toward the staircase. Ade and Kai follow his gaze. The landing is empty. Solomon's bedroom door stands open.

Malik turns away first. On the dining table, the BRASS URN waits beside a vase of white flowers.

Smaller than the silence around it. Malik lifts it. Tests the lid. Once. Again. A faint thumbprint marks the polished brass. He wipes it with his sleeve. The print smears. He wipes harder.

ADE

Malik.

Malik stops. Ade holds out both hands.

ADE

Let me.

Malik looks at the hands. Then at Ade.

MALIK

Take the flowers.

Ade leaves his hands there for another beat. Then takes the vase. Kai switches off the kitchen light. Dawn does the rest. The brothers move toward the door: Ade with flowers and garment bags.

Kai with his camera and the funeral programmes. Malik with their father. Before Kai leaves, he looks back at the crooked photograph. He does not straighten it. The front door closes.

CUT TO:

EXT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - MEMORIAL LAWN - MORNING

Rain hangs in the air without committing to a drop. A white canopy has been raised among cedars. Beneath it: Folding chairs. White flowers. A framed photograph of Solomon. The brass urn at the center. No grave.

A small Nigerian choir sings beside a portable speaker. The sound is beautiful until the speaker dries it into static. Mourners fill the chairs.

Black Canadian wool beside Nigerian formal wear. Old friends from church. Former patients from Solomon's clinic. Neighbours who knew the shape of his car better than the shape of his life.

The brothers stand in the front row. Malik nearest the urn. He has folded the programme into a perfect rectangle. Ade receives condolences with both hands. He gives each person the response they need.

KAI stands half a step behind them. His camera hangs unused. The OFFICIANT reads from the repaired Efik Bible.

OFFICIANT

We return Solomon Oku to the
keeping of those who loved him,
and we give thanks for the life
he shared with us.

Malik's eyes move to the order of service. Final prayer. Hymn. Family departure. He checks that the choir is ready before the officiant has finished speaking. The choir leader raises one hand. The microphone SHRIEKS.

Ordinary feedback. Metallic and sudden. Everyone flinches. Kai folds around the sound. One hand clamps over his right ear. The choir, the rain, the murmuring crowd - all of it collapses into a thin electrical ring.

The officiant's mouth keeps moving. No words reach him. Ade sees. He steps close enough for Kai to feel him.

ADE

Kai.

Kai watches Ade's lips.

ADE

Look at me.

Kai does. Ade breathes slowly. Kai matches him. The speaker is switched off. The ringing recedes. Sound returns in pieces: Shoes shifting on wet grass. Someone coughing into a handkerchief.

The choir continuing without amplification. Malik turns at last.

MALIK

You all right?

KAI

It was loud.

MALIK

I know.

Kai looks at Ade. Ade holds his gaze. At the rear of the canopy, a man waits beside a small travel bag. BODE OKU, 64. Solomon's younger brother.

Rain has darkened the shoulders of his coat. An airline tag still circles the handle of his bag. He arrived too late to hide how far he came. He does not interrupt. He removes his cap for the final prayer.

Malik sees him. Something in Malik's posture hardens before it gives way. The prayer ends. The choir's last note thins beneath the canopy. People rise. Condolences begin moving toward the brothers.

Bode waits until the oldest church women have passed. Then he approaches. He looks at Malik first.

BODE

Malik.

Malik takes his uncle's hand. Bode draws him into a brief, private embrace. He greets Ade. Then Kai.

Kai feels the travel still in Bode's coat: rain, recycled air, a trace of cologne applied in another time zone. Bode looks at the urn. Then back to Malik.

BODE

Was it peaceful?

Malik answers without looking away.

MALIK

Yes.

Ade lowers his eyes. Kai studies Malik. Bode waits. Malik does not revise the answer.

BODE

Good.

A beat.

ADE

You made it.

BODE

Your father spent seventeen years accusing me of being late.

ADE

Was he right?

BODE

Only when somebody else was waiting.

Bode looks at the photograph beside the urn.

BODE

At sixteen, he missed the school bus and ran behind it with his shoes in his hands.

KAI

Why was he not wearing them?

BODE

He said shoes made a man slow.

ADE

Dad said that?

BODE

At sixteen? He said many things.

Ade laughs. One clean breath of it. Even Malik almost does. The FUNERAL DIRECTOR approaches with respectful distance.

FUNERAL DIRECTOR

Mr. Oku. Whenever your family is ready, you may take the urn.

Malik moves before anyone else can. He gathers the urn against his chest. Ade reaches for the flowers. Bode watches the order settle into place.

FUNERAL DIRECTOR

The reception room is through the south doors.

MALIK

Thank you.

Malik takes one step. His grip tightens. The urn slips less than an inch. His entire body reacts. Bode puts one

hand beneath the base. Malik does not release it. Bode does not pull.

They stand like that while mourners move around them.

MALIK

I have it.

BODE

I know.

Malik's fingers whiten against the brass.

MALIK

I'm trying not to make another mistake for him.

Bode keeps his hand beneath the urn.

BODE

Give me one side.

Malik looks at his uncle's hand. Then shifts his grip enough to make space. Bode takes half the weight. They carry Solomon toward the reception room together. Ade follows with the flowers.

Kai picks up Bode's travel bag.

INT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - RECEPTION ROOM - LATER

Condensation clouds the windows. Coats steam on chair backs. Jollof rice, meat pies, fried plantain, tea. Solomon's brass urn rests where Malik can see it from anywhere in the room.

Mourners contradict one another over the man he was. A woman tells Ade he has Solomon's laugh. Ade thanks her. For the rest of the reception, he smiles without showing his teeth. Malik keeps one hand on the back of the chair nearest the urn.

Kai stops at a photograph on the memorial table. Three young people outside a weathered house: SOLOMON, lean and unsmiling. BODE, younger, one hand raised against the sun. A GIRL between them.

Her face has been scratched away. Not crossed out with ink. Cut from the emulsion with a sharp point, stroke after deliberate stroke. Kai tilts the photograph. The grooves catch the fluorescent light.

Ade steps in beside him. His social smile disappears.

ADE

That was done on purpose.

In the background of the photograph, a brass object rests on the veranda wall. Too small to identify. The same compact silhouette as the carving in Solomon's blue drawer. Bode steps into the edge of their silence.

He sees the photograph. His face settles.

KAI

Who was she?

BODE

My sister.

ADE

Did he do this?

BODE

Not here.

Bode glances at two mourners close enough to hear. Malik joins them.

MALIK

What is it?

Kai gives him the photograph. Malik reads the damage before he reads the people.

BODE

Solomon's lawyer will come to the house tomorrow morning.

MALIK

Why?

BODE

The will.

MALIK

You know what is in it.

BODE

Solomon left instructions. They are for his sons.

Malik looks from the scratched face to the urn.

EXT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - PARKING AREA - AFTERNOON

The rain finally commits. Bode and Malik carry the urn between them beneath one umbrella. The umbrella is too small. Ade walks ahead to open the car.

Kai follows with Bode's travel bag and the scratched photograph protected inside his coat. At the back door, Bode offers to take the urn completely. Malik considers it.

MALIK

One side.

Bode nods. Together, they place Solomon inside.

CUT TO:

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - DINING ROOM - MORNING

The flowers from the funeral have begun to open. The urn stands on the sideboard. The damaged photograph lies face-up on the dining table. Beside it: The brass carving from the blue drawer.

Kai has brought the two objects together. MAYA PATEL, 48, Solomon's estate lawyer, has one slim file and a sealed envelope. Bode sits apart from the brothers.

MAYA

The legal part is simple.

MALIK

That usually means the opposite.

MAYA

Your father left the Oku family house and its adjoining land outside Calabar to the three of you. One undivided gift.

ADE

And if one of us says no?

MAYA

It remains with the family there. You owe nothing. You may refuse.

She places the sealed envelope between them.

MAYA

This is not legally binding. It is for you.

Malik opens it. One sheet in Solomon's tight handwriting. He reads silently. His jaw sets.

ADE

You have to use sound.

Malik gives him the page. Ade reads.

ADE

"My sons. I need you to take me home. All three. Bring my ashes to the river boundary of the Oku land outside Calabar."

No farewell. No signature.

MALIK

He is dead and still assigning seats.

MAYA

You may say no.

MALIK

Did he make the land conditional on it?

MAYA

No. The ashes are a request. The property is a choice the three of you make together. Your uncle agreed to guide you if you go. That is all the will can usefully say.

She closes her file. Malik walks her out.

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - DINING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Ade holds Solomon's letter. Kai has turned the scratched photograph toward Bode.

KAI

The house in this photograph. Is that it?

BODE

Yes.

Kai places the carving beside the tiny brass shape on the veranda wall. Same broad shoulders. Same narrow center.

KAI

And her?

BODE

Our sister.

KAI

She died there?

BODE

She died. The rest belongs in Calabar.

Malik returns. Takes Solomon's letter from Ade.

MALIK

We are not going.

KAI

You decided quickly.

MALIK

Three people crossing an ocean because a dead man could not speak while he was alive.

ADE

He said what he wanted.

MALIK

He gave us a location.

ADE

For Dad, that was practically intimacy.

Malik does not smile.

KAI

He hid the carving. He kept this picture and destroyed her face. Now he wants all three of us at the house they came from.

MALIK

That is not a pattern. That is an estate.

KAI

It is when everyone refuses the same part of it.

Bode absorbs that.

MALIK

You want to fly across the world
because people are withholding
information?

KAI

He kept her picture.

Kai taps the scratched face.

KAI

He kept that carving.

Then Solomon's letter.

KAI

And this is the first time he put
all three things in the same
place.

Malik turns to Bode.

MALIK

Tell him not to go.

BODE

No.

MALIK

You know what is there.

BODE

I know some of what is there.

MALIK

Then decide.

BODE

It is not mine to decide.

Malik stiffens. Kai looks to Ade. Ade gets up, crosses to
the refrigerator and opens it. Three mustards. He takes
out the grainy one. Stares at it.

ADE

He arranged the room before he
left it.

MALIK

What?

ADE

Dad in the middle. Us around him.
I hate that it worked.

MALIK

Then say no.

ADE

And let Kai go by himself?

MALIK

He doesn't have to go.

ADE

You know him.

Kai looks at Ade.

ADE

We go together. We carry Dad to the river. We ask what we need to ask. Then we come home together.

Kai raises one hand.

KAI

Yes.

Malik looks at both of them. They wait for him. Neither looks away. He unfolds Solomon's letter. Smooths the crease Ade made.

MALIK

We go together.

Kai waits.

MALIK

We stay together.

ADE

That sounded threatening.

MALIK

It was a condition.

ADE

There he is.

The sound of the room gives way to a SEAT BELT CHIME.

PILOT (V.O.)

Cabin crew, prepare for landing in Calabar.

CUT TO:

INT. DOMESTIC AIRCRAFT - DESCENDING - AFTERNOON

Green gathers beneath the wing. Water catches the sky between broad seams of land. The brothers look down at a place their father spent thirty years refusing to describe.

The urn remains in its padded case beneath Malik's seat. His shoes bracket it. Across the aisle, Bode watches the ground rise to meet them.

WHEELS STRIKE RUNWAY.

EXT. MARGARET EKPO INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT - ARRIVALS - AFTERNOON

The doors open. Heat arrives like a hand laid flat against the face. Sound follows: Car horns. Names called across traffic. Trolley wheels hitting broken pavement. An argument ending in laughter.

The brothers step out carrying Vancouver in the cut of their clothes. Sweat finds them immediately.

ADE
Canada has been lying about
weather.

The airport keeps everyone close enough to negotiate with.
A PORTER, twenties, moves toward their luggage.

PORTER
Oga, make I help.

He takes hold of Ade's suitcase before anyone answers.
Malik pulls it back.

MALIK
No. Leave it.

The porter keeps one hand on the handle.

PORTER
No worry. I go carry am.

Bode steps beside Malik. He does not raise his voice.

BODE
My brother, leave am. We no need
help.

The porter looks at Bode. Releases the handle.

PORTER
No vex, sir.

Bode nods.

BODE
No problem.

The whole exchange takes five seconds. Malik is still
holding the suitcase too tightly. Bode takes the trolley.

BODE
Come.

The brothers do.

EXT. CALABAR ROAD - BODE'S VEHICLE - LATER

The city passes in layers. Painted shopfronts. Church
signs. School uniforms. Palm shadows sliding across
windshields. Red earth appearing wherever pavement gives
up. Kai films through the window. People.

A mechanic asleep beneath a lifted car. Two girls sharing
earphones. A woman balancing bread on her head while
texting. Bode points through the windscreen toward a road
disappearing into green.

BODE
Your father used to race bicycle
there.

ADE
Dad had a bicycle?

BODE
Your father had a childhood.

KAI

We have not seen evidence.

BODE

He had legs too.

Ade laughs. Malik looks out at the road. For one moment, he tries to place his father on it. Cannot. The city thins. Walls give way to compounds. The air grows greener. Bode turns onto a narrower road.

BODE

Home.

Tires leave asphalt for red earth.

CUT TO:

EXT. OKU FAMILY COMPOUND - LATE AFTERNOON

A broad family compound shaped by additions rather than a single plan. An older central house with deep verandas. A newer concrete wing. Solar panels beside a corrugated roof. Carved doors. Plastic water tanks.

Children's bicycles. Satellite dishes. Laundry moving in the heat. Every part of the compound is in use. The vehicle enters through an open gate. People come out before the engine stops.

COUSIN EYO, 43, practical and quick, opens the rear hatch. Children crowd the brothers until one look from Eyo restores a lane. Then AUNTIE ENO, early sixties, crosses the veranda. She does not hurry.

Everyone else adjusts around her pace. Bode steps forward.

BODE

M■k■m, Eno.

ENO

Ek■m do.

Eno touches his cheek. Counts the months since she last saw him without asking. Then she turns to the brothers. Malik offers his hand.

ENO

That is all?

MALIK

Good afternoon, Aunty.

ENO

M■k■m.

MALIK

M■k■m, Aunty.

ENO

Better.

She ignores the hand and takes his face between both of hers. Turns it toward the light.

ENO

Solomon kept this forehead in
Canada.

Malik does not know whether he has been welcomed or
examined. Eno releases him. Ade opens his arms.

ADE

I prepared for a hug.

ENO

You people came from Canada and
forgot how to greet?

Ade lowers his arms.

ADE

M■k■m, Auntie Eno.

He bows his head just enough to make the respect clear
without pretending fluency he does not have.

ENO

This one still has mouth.

She pulls him into an embrace. Ade closes his eyes inside
it. Only for a second. Eno turns to Kai. He has already
removed his camera from between them.

KAI

M■k■m, Auntie.

ENO

And this one came to inspect us.

KAI

I am just looking.

ENO

Then greet what you are looking
at.

She touches his cheek once. Gentler than the sentence.
Then she sees the padded black case in Malik's hand. The
compound quiets by degrees. Bode takes off his cap.

BODE

We brought him.

Eno approaches the case. She does not open it. She lays
her palm on the lid. The gesture is ordinary. The grief is
not.

ENO

You took your time, Solomon.

She removes her hand.

ENO

Bring him inside before the heat
insults him. The rest of you -
wash. You look like the airport
has eaten you.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The front room carries several generations without arranging them for visitors. Family portraits. School certificates. A charging station crowded with phones.

An old cabinet of carved wood beneath a flat-screen television. Wide doors open onto the veranda and the courtyard beyond.

The kitchen has its own door onto that same courtyard. Between the kitchen wall and the older rear rooms, a narrow BACK PASSAGE runs deeper into the house and drops three shallow steps below the main floor.

The brass urn is placed on a sturdy side table. Malik checks the surface first. Solid. Level. Eno watches him test it.

ENO

If the table survived this family, it can hold your father.

Malik removes his hand. Children peer through the doorway. Eno turns.

ENO

Give them air.

They disappear. Not far.

At the far end of the back passage, a narrow door is secured by a faded RED CORD looped between its handle and a brass wall hook. It is the only door in the house that does not stand open.

Kai notices. Eno notices him noticing.

Eyo crosses the mouth of the back passage with folded bedding. For a moment he blocks Kai's view. When he clears it, the red-corded door is still there.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - DINING ROOM - DUSK

Food reaches the table before questions do. Afang soup. Fufu. Rice. Fried plantain. Grilled fish. Water sweating in glass bottles. The brothers sit among relatives whose names arrive faster than memory can keep them.

Eno serves Malik until he says enough. Then adds one more spoon.

MALIK

Aunty, thank you. That is enough.

ENO

You want to bargain with soup now?

ADE

He does it with eggs too.

ENO

Tomorrow I will give him eggs. We will see who wins.

Ade looks at his plate.

ADE

I should warn you, I can cook.

Eno gives him a careful look.

ENO

Cook first.

A beat.

ENO

Then warn me.

The table erupts. Ade accepts the hit. Eyo points his spoon at Bode.

EYO

Tell them about the mangoes.

BODE

There is nothing to tell.

ENO

Because you helped him.

ADE

Dad stole mangoes?

BODE

Borrowed.

ENO

From trees that did not belong to him.

BODE

The trees recovered.

EYO

He sold them back to the owner.

Malik laughs. He looks as startled as anyone. Covers it with water.

ADE

What else could he do?

Eno thinks.

ENO

At twelve he learned how to boil water.

BODE

Eleven.

ENO

Twelve. For one month he entered the kitchen asking why everybody was still working without him.

Ade folds over laughing, one hand braced against the table. He does not check whether anyone follows. Kai smiles. Malik looks toward the urn in the front room.

MALIK

He never told us any of this.

The laughter eases.

Eno looks at the urn.

ENO

Solomon did not like his children
laughing at him.

ADE

We would have survived the
mangoes.

ENO

Mangoes, yes.

Bode and Eno share a glance. Small. Old. Kai catches it.

MALIK

What happened here?

ENO

Tonight? You arrived. You ate.
Your uncle exaggerated mangoes.

BODE

You accused me first.

ENO

Tomorrow Bode will show you the
land. Ask him what he knows.

KAI

And you?

ENO

I cooked.

She reaches for his plate. Kai protects it.

KAI

I'm still eating.

ENO

Then eat.

The conversation starts again around them. Through the doorway, the urn catches the room light.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BROTHERS' ROOM - NIGHT

Three narrow beds. Three mosquito nets tied up for air. Suitcases open on the floor. The room is hot enough to make sleep theoretical. Ade lies on one bed, still smiling at the ceiling.

ADE

Mangoes.

MALIK

Go to sleep.

ADE

He sold stolen mangoes back to
the man.

KAI

Allegedly.

ADE

No. That is our father. I finally
have a complete fact.

Malik removes his watch. Sets it beside the bed.

MALIK

You have a story.

ADE

I will take it.

Kai sits with the scratched photograph. He has placed the
brass carving beside it.

MALIK

Put those away.

KAI

The object in the background is
the same.

MALIK

We established that.

KAI

No one at dinner mentioned her.

ADE

You did not ask.

KAI

They knew I had already asked.

Malik looks at Bode's younger face in the photograph. Then
at the missing one between the brothers.

MALIK

Tomorrow.

Kai looks at him.

MALIK

Not as an answer. As a time.

Kai wraps the photograph again. The brothers settle.
Outside: Family voices on the veranda. Cutlery being
washed. A generator starting two compounds away.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BREAKFAST AREA - MORNING

Morning arrives already loud. Eggs. Fried plantain. Bread.
Tea. The Afang soup from last night, because Eno does not
believe good food must respect the clock.

ENO

Emesiere.

The brothers answer with varying confidence.

BROTHERS

Emesiere nde.

Eno nods. Malik eats the eggs. She watches.

ENO

Well?

MALIK

They are very good.

ENO

Not "very good." Who won?

Malik surrenders one inch.

MALIK

The eggs.

Eno nods. Order restored. Bode enters dressed for the land. Light shirt. Sturdy shoes. A folded map he does not need. Malik notices the map.

BODE

We leave in twenty minutes.

ADE

Now he speaks your language.

BODE

The river path is long. We will show you the boundaries first. If the weather holds, we continue to the water.

Malik looks toward the urn in the front room.

MALIK

Today?

BODE

Today we walk. At the river, you decide if today is the day.

The brothers finish eating.

CUT TO:

EXT. OKU FAMILY COMPOUND - MORNING

Eyo secures water and food in a canvas pack. The brass urn remains inside its padded case. Malik lifts it. Ade reaches for one handle. Malik lets him. Together, they carry Solomon through the gate.

Eno stands on the veranda.

ENO

Bring everybody back before dark.

ADE

No instruction for the dead?

ENO

He has ignored enough instructions.

Bode almost smiles. The four men follow a red-earth path into the family land.

EXT. OKU FAMILY LAND - LATER

The compound disappears behind green. The land is not untouched. It has been worked, abandoned, reclaimed and worked again. Cassava plots. Palm stands. Old drainage cuts softened by rain.

New survey stakes beside boundary stones older than anyone present. Bode stops at the first stone. Three shallow cuts cross its face.

BODE

From here to the river bend. Then east to the old road.

Malik studies the folded map.

MALIK

The title says forty-two hectares.

BODE

The title learned the land later.

Malik looks up. Bode points.

BODE

That silk-cotton tree was already old when your grandfather was born.

ADE

Does the tree have paperwork?

BODE

Better witnesses.

They continue. Kai photographs the stone. The three cuts converge around a shallow hollow. He takes the brass carving from his camera bag and holds it beside the mark. The angles differ. Both hollows sit slightly off-center.

KAI

Uncle Bode.

Bode looks from one mark to the other.

BODE

It marks Oku land.

KAI

And the carving?

BODE

It came from here.

KAI

Was it hers?

Bode looks at the carving.

BODE

Put it away.

Kai wraps the carving and returns it to his bag. They walk.

EXT. OLD PALM TRACK - LATER

The path narrows beneath a layered canopy. Heat becomes wet pressure. The urn passes from Malik and Ade to Malik and Bode. Then to Ade alone for a short rise. Each transfer is careful. No ceremony. Practice.

Bode points to a tree bent low across the path.

BODE

Solomon planted that after our mother said nothing useful would grow where he put it.

ADE

Spite farming.

BODE

Your father's most reliable crop.

The tree is enormous now. Malik touches its trunk as he passes. Farther on, the path divides around a washout. Bode stops the group.

BODE

From here, stay where I can see you.

ADE

You say that like we've been freelancing.

BODE

Last rain took part of this path. There are old drops under the vines.

He indicates the left fork.

BODE

No shortcut.

Bode takes the left fork. The others follow.

EXT. BOUNDARY PATH - LATER

The boundary stones return at no regular distance. Each one stands on the right side of the path.

A fallen limb has peeled vines from the slope to Kai's left. Beneath them: An older stone carrying the same three cuts. Facing downhill.

Kai raises his camera. Ahead, Malik and Ade negotiate the urn over a fallen trunk. Bode watches their footing.

Kai steps off the path to frame the exposed stone.

EXT. SLOPE ABOVE THE RAVINE - CONTINUOUS

He takes two careful steps. Wet leaves shear away beneath his shoe. The slope gives. Kai slides, camera clutched to his chest. His free hand catches a root. The root tears loose.

Kai drops into the ravine.

EXT. HIDDEN SHRINE - CONTINUOUS

He lands hard enough to empty his lungs. For several seconds: Mud. Breath. Pain. Kai checks the camera. Unbroken. One scraped palm.

The exposed boundary stone is not freestanding. It is the upper corner of a SHRINE.

Stone and tree have grown into one body. The masonry rises from the ravine wall, soft at the edges from age. Roots enter through old seams and emerge as carved lines. Some roots protect it.

Others brace its seams where stone and earth have shifted against each other. At its center: A narrow recess covered by a small slab of wood. The wood is bound to the stone with faded RED THREAD.

Pale grooves circle the wood at different heights beneath the thread. Earlier bindings. Kai remains where he fell. He looks up the slope. The family is no longer visible. Movement somewhere above. No words he can make out.

Kai takes the carving from his camera bag. The roots describe the same three cuts around a hollow. He holds the carving beside them. Photographs both.

Kai approaches. He touches the wood. Dry beneath the damp air. The red thread crosses itself in a practiced knot. One loop can be loosened without cutting.

Kai works a fingertip beneath the loop. The thread resists. He stops. Looks back toward the slope. Pulls again.

The old thread snaps -- a dry little sound. The forest continues around him. Insects. Birds. Leaves rubbing in the upper air. Kai catches the wooden cover before it falls.

Behind it, a recess blackened by age. Inside: A BRASS TALISMAN. Palm-sized. Green at the edges. Its design holds the same three converging lines.

A dark fracture interrupts the filled center. Not a clean break. Fine brass dust has settled beneath it; the back half remains bedded deep in stone. The exposed half answers Kai's fingertip with a thin, unpleasant vibration.

Kai photographs the fracture. Studies the two halves together. Then deliberately lifts the exposed half free with two fingers.

The moment the brass fragment clears the recess --

Insects. Birds. The upper leaves.

Gone.

The broken half pulls heat from Kai's fingers.

Metal floods the back of his tongue.

Kai swallows.

The recess doubles for half a blink.

Then one again.

Another PALM beneath his. Older. Red thread cutting across both hands.

River water at his chest.

Somewhere below --

BRASS STRIKES STONE.

Kai drops to one knee. His jaw locks against a cry. The brass half remains in his fist. The other half still sits in the recess, its fractured edge exposed at eye level.

His free hand moves toward it. Stops.

The ground answers with one DEEP BEAT. Impact through root and stone. Kai feels it in his teeth. High above, leaves turn their pale undersides toward the ravine.

MALIK (O.S.)

Kai!

Kai raises the fragment toward its other half. Holds it one inch from where it sat.

MALIK (O.S.)

Kai!

Kai closes his hand. Slips the broken half into his camera bag, beside the separately wrapped older carving.

At the base of the shrine, something moves. A BLACK SPIDER emerges from the seam between root and stone. Small. Unhurried. It crosses the snapped red thread.

Stops on the broken loop.

BODE (O.S.)

Kai!

Bode's voice cracks on the name. Kai looks toward the slope. Then back at the shrine. The spider begins to follow the broken thread toward open ground.

CUT TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

EXT. OKU FAMILY LAND - RIVER BOUNDARY - LATE AFTERNOON

The river moves beneath a low amber sky.

Broad. Brown. Unhurried.

Leaves and reflected light travel the current. The forest crowds both banks, older than everyone standing before it.

Bode removes his sandals and leaves them beside the exposed roots of a tree. He steps into the water until it reaches his ankles. Bends. Touches two fingers to the current.

Waits.

Then looks back at the brothers.

BODE

Face the current.

Malik removes his shoes. Ade follows.

Kai is last. Mud dries across one knee. His camera bag hangs high against his chest. Malik looks at Kai's closed, scraped hand. Kai enters the water.

Bode returns to the bank and steps back from the water.

The BRASS URN rests in Malik's hands.

Smaller now than the journey built around it.

Malik opens it. Looks down at the ash. His fingers tighten around the rim.

Ade steps beside him. Places one hand on Malik's shoulder.

Malik looks to Kai.

Kai nods.

Malik tips the urn.

The first ash touches the river and spreads in pale veils. Some sinks immediately. Some catches the current.

No music.

Water against their legs. Leaves shifting above them. Insects working invisibly in the heat.

Malik tips the urn farther. Ade lowers his head. Kai follows each grey strand until the river takes it.

A last dusting gathers along the lip.

Malik taps the base once.

One narrow ribbon of ash settles on the current.

The water moves beneath it.

The ash holds.

Kai sees it.

Then the ribbon opens. Separates. Disappears.

The river continues.

A bird calls beyond the trees.

Malik lowers the empty urn. Kneels. Rinses the ash from his fingertips.

The grey leaves his skin.

When he stands, his shoulders sit lower.

Ade looks downstream. Opens his mouth. Closes it.

Kai shuts his eyes.

The brothers remain in the current. Wind moves over the water. Sunlight breaks across it.

Then one insect stops.

A thin metallic chirr from the left bank cuts off mid-pulse.

Another disappears farther in.

Then another.

The change travels through the forest.

Life withdrawing from sound.

Ade opens his eyes.

The breeze weakens. Leaves settle. The surface of the river smooths around their legs.

A bird lands above the bank.

Does not call.

Malik's hand rises to the back of his neck.

He looks over his shoulder.

Only water. Only forest.

His body locks.

One second.

Air returns to him. He lowers his hand.

Ade turns toward the bank. The beginning of a smile finds his face.

No joke follows.

Kai remains facing downstream. His gaze fixes beyond the bend.

The trees seem closer.

He blinks.

They are where they were.

Malik stops breathing.

Ade's unfinished smile disappears.

Kai's shoulders draw tight.

All at once.

Nothing touches them.

None of them turns.

The moment passes.

Wind crosses the river. Insects restart unevenly. The bird leaves the branch. Water breaks around their ankles.

Malik steps first. Ade follows. Kai waits a beat before moving.

They leave the river separately, though they entered it together.

Bode watches from the bank.

Malik rubs the back of his neck and reaches for his collar.

Ade says nothing.

Kai keeps his eyes from the trees.

Bode looks past them toward the river.

Nothing there.

He picks up Malik's shoes and hands them over.

BODE

Let's go.

The brothers dress. Bode starts up the path faster than he walked down.

Still short of a run.

The brothers follow.

None of them looks back.

Behind them, the current passes over the place where the ash held together.

Nothing holds there now.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BROTHERS' ROOM - NIGHT

The mosquito nets are down.

Three pale rooms inside one dark room.

The ceiling fan turns above them. Its bearings complain once each revolution.

Outside: A basin empties. Two women finish a conversation on the veranda. A child objects to bedtime and is carried away still arguing.

The house settles around its living.

Malik lies awake. The EMPTY BRASS URN rests inside its padded case beside his bed.

Ade faces the ceiling.

Kai lies nearest the door. His camera bag sits beneath his hand.

Nobody is sleeping.

ADE

Anybody going to say it?

MALIK

Say what?

ADE

Fine.

Ade rolls onto his side.

ADE

Beautiful river. Lovely family outing. Nobody left it terrified.

Malik looks at him through the net.

Kai does not.

KAI

You felt it.

MALIK

I felt something.

ADE

Thank you.

MALIK

That was not agreement.

A small smile almost reaches Kai.

Outside, one insect stops.

Kai's eyes move to the window.

A second call disappears farther across the compound.

Then another.

The subtraction moves toward the house.

Ade sits up.

Malik swings his feet to the floor.

The last voice on the veranda stops.

The fan continues.

Once each revolution --

its bearing complains.

The open doorway frames the passage.

At the far end: the RED-CORDED DOOR.

Moonlight enters through patterned ventilation blocks.

Four pale bands lie across the passage floor.

Kai stares.

Five.

He blinks.

Four.

KAI

Malik.

Malik is beside his net immediately.

MALIK

What?

Kai points.

The bands remain still.

Their spacing does not.

The third appears farther from the second than the passage can contain.

Ade steps down from his bed.

MALIK

Stay there.

ADE

I'm beside the bed.

Malik looks.

He is.

At the far end of the passage, beside the red-corded door
--

something prevents the wall from resolving.

Not a shadow.

Not a body.

A vertical interruption in the room's depth.

Kai leans toward it.

The interruption acquires a bend.

Too high for a shoulder.

Another lower down.

The first is no longer where it was.

ADE

Kai.

Kai does not answer.

His hand rises to the back of his neck.

The passage contracts.

The red-corded door appears six feet away.

Then twelve.

Then close enough to touch.

Kai moves.

Malik catches his forearm before his foot clears the
bedroom.

KAI

I wasn't --

MALIK

You were.

Kai looks down.

His toes are over the threshold.

Malik pulls him back one step.

The distance to the thing does not change.

Kai looks again.

Height gathers around it.

Too much height.

A narrow upper mass continues into the place where the ceiling should end it.

One articulation folds sideways without shortening.

Another seems nearer than the part connecting it.

Almost anatomy.

Kai forgets to breathe.

The form resolves another fraction.

Malik steps between Kai and the passage.

KAI

Move.

MALIK

No.

KAI

Malik --

MALIK

Look at me.

Kai tries to see around him.

Malik catches the other shoulder.

MALIK

Kai.

Ade moves in close behind Malik. No joke now.

ADE

Look at him.

Kai's eyes finally find Malik's.

Malik does not let go.

The fan turns.

One bearing complaint.

Then another.

Outside, an insect begins again.

Farther away than it should be.

Ade looks past Malik.

The passage is empty.

Four bands of moonlight.

The red cord at the far door.

Wall.

Nothing crosses out of sight.

Nothing leaves.

Malik releases one of Kai's shoulders.

Not the other.

MALIK

You with me?

Kai nods once.

His eyes drift toward the passage.

Malik tightens his hand.

KAI

It kept getting clearer.

Malik follows Kai's gaze to the red-corded door.

Then down to the camera bag beneath Kai's bed.

Kai sees where he is looking.

A beat.

KAI

There's something I didn't tell
you.

CUT TO:

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

One burner holds a kettle below a full boil.

Bode sits at the table in a white undershirt. He has
turned on one light and no more.

The brothers enter barefoot together.

Malik stays between Kai and the passage.

Ade closes the kitchen door.

Bode looks from one face to the next.

BODE

What happened?

MALIK

Show him.

Kai sets his camera on the table.

Finds the image.

The hidden shrine in the ravine.

Root and stone grown together.

Wooden cover.

Red binding intact.

Bode leans closer.

His hand stops short of the camera.

BODE

Where?

KAI

Below the western stones.

Bode looks at him.

BODE
You left the path.

KAI
I slipped after.

BODE
After.

Kai advances the image.
The red thread broken.
The recess open.
Bode stands.

BODE
Kai.
Not anger.
Worse.
Malik turns to Kai.

MALIK
What did you take?
Kai opens the camera bag.
Removes the BROKEN HALF OF THE BRASS TALISMAN.
Sets it on the table.
Bode steps back.
A bedroom door opens somewhere off the passage.
Malik does not notice.

MALIK
You carried that to the river.

KAI
Yes.

MALIK
You stood beside us with it.

KAI
Yes.

MALIK
And said nothing.

KAI
Yes.

Ade looks at the fractured edge.

ADE
Why keep it?

Kai looks at the broken half.

KAI
The other side was still there.

KAI
I wanted to know what it was.

MALIK
So you took it.

KAI
I almost put it back.

MALIK
You didn't.

KAI
No.

Footsteps approach in the passage.

Bode is still looking at the open-recess photograph.

KAI
Do you know what it is?

BODE
No.

KAI
The place.

Bode takes longer.

BODE
We were told to leave that part
of the land alone.

MALIK
By who?

BODE
My father. Then Solomon.

MALIK
Why?

BODE
I don't know.

MALIK
What do you know?

Bode looks at the photograph.

BODE
My sister died.

The kitchen door opens.

Eno stands there in a wrapper over her nightclothes.

She has heard enough to know nobody is discussing sleep.

ENO
What happened?

No one answers quickly.

She enters.

Sees the brass object on her table.

ENO

Whose is that?

KAI

I took it from the land.

ENO

From where?

Bode answers before Kai can.

BODE

Western stones.

Eno looks at Bode.

He does not meet it.

ENO

And he brought it here.

BODE

Yes.

Eno takes a clean dishcloth from the counter.

Drops it over the broken brass half without touching it.

ENO

Then it stays there.

She looks at Kai.

ENO

You don't know what it is and you
carried it into my house?

Kai nods.

Malik has not left Bode.

MALIK

Your sister.

Bode sits again.

BODE

Solomon came home from the land
without her.

Kai watches him.

KAI

Was she there?

BODE

Yes.

KAI

At that place?

BODE

I don't know.

MALIK

Then what changed?

Bode looks toward the passage.

BODE

Solomon.

A beat.

BODE

He stopped laughing for a long time.

Ade looks down.

BODE

Then he started going back.

MALIK

To the land.

Bode nods.

BODE

And the room.

Eno's eyes move to him.

She knows exactly which room.

ADE

What room?

Eno answers.

ENO

The one at the end of the passage.

Kai looks toward the kitchen door.

MALIK

What's in it?

BODE

Records.

ENO

His work.

Bode looks at her.

ENO

Call it what it was. He worked in there.

MALIK

You read them?

BODE

Some.

MALIK

Enough to fix it?

BODE

No.

KAI

Enough to know if I caused this?

Bode looks at him.

BODE

No.

Kai absorbs that.

BODE

But Solomon went back there for
years.

He looks at the covered brass half.

BODE

You went once and brought
something home.

Malik reaches for the dishcloth.

Eno slaps his hand away.

Not hard.

Final.

ENO

I said it stays.

Malik looks at her.

ENO

Three of you came into this
kitchen barefoot and shaking.
Nobody is taking anything
anywhere tonight.

She points toward the brothers' room.

ENO

Together.

Then to Bode.

ENO

Morning, you open Solomon's room.

BODE

Eno --

ENO

Before breakfast.

Ade almost smiles.

Almost.

Eno catches it.

ENO

You too.

The almost-smile disappears.

ENO

Go.

The brothers go.

Bode remains seated beneath the single kitchen light.

Eno turns off the burner.

The kettle never reaches a boil.

CUT TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BACK PASSAGE - MORNING

Courtyard daylight reaches only the first half of the passage.

Three shallow steps drop into the oldest part of the house. The RED-CORDED DOOR waits at the low end, away from the front rooms and out of sight from most of the courtyard.

Children argue somewhere at the front of the house.

A radio gives the weather.

Bode stands before the door with a small ring of household keys.

Malik, Ade and Kai behind him.

Eno arrives carrying nothing.

The broken brass half remains in the kitchen beneath the dishcloth.

Bode touches the cord.

A simple hitch between handle and brass wall hook.

Nothing like the worked binding at the shrine.

His fingers pause.

ENO

Bode.

He undoes it.

The door is unlocked.

He opens it.

Beyond it --

A steep stone staircase descends past the depth the house should allow. The daylight gives out before the turn.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - MAINTENANCE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Deep beneath the house. A circular chamber older than every room above it. Stone rises into a high, closed dome.

Camphor.

Paper.

Machine oil.

One shaded practical lamp. No window. Family voices reach the chamber only by the staircase.

A long worktable against the near curved wall.

A measuring line worn dark where fingers held it.

Brass cloths blackened at the folds.

Bundles of red cotton wrapped by weight and date.

A boundary map punctured and corrected until the western edge is nearly soft.

Malik stops at the table.

Kai does not enter as far.

At the opposite wall --

AN INNER DOOR.

Old maintained wood centered in the far curved wall. A restrained line of worn gold marks its threshold.

From its brass frame, braided RED LOAD LINES divide across the walls, climb the dome and disappear into narrow floor channels. Copper guides carry them toward marks on the boundary map: WEST. RIVER. OLD ROAD.

Two open brass forearm bands hang inactive from separate guide lines near the center of the room. An old dark stain has entered the porous stone beneath them. Someone scrubbed around it for years.

The lines are fixed at both ends. Nothing loose reaches for anyone.

Nothing moves.

The door is still.

Kai looks at Bode.

KAI

What's behind it?

BODE

I don't know.

Malik looks over.

BODE

Solomon never opened it for me.

Eno watches the boys take in the room.

ENO

After she died, Solomon stopped letting anybody down here.

Bode looks at her.

Eno does not add anything.

Bode opens a cabinet.

Ledgers wrapped against humidity.

He places one on the table.

Malik opens it.

Narrow block letters.

Dates.

Measurements.

A ruled margin corrected where the pencil drifted.

WEST BINDING — REPLACED
RIVER +11 CM BRASS — CLEAN

Malik's thumb stops beside a knot diagram.

MALIK

Dad.

Bode nods.

Malik turns pages.

A date from years after Solomon moved to Canada.

Then another.

He looks at Eno.

MALIK

He was here.

ENO

Yes.

On another shelf, Kai sees thinner cloth-bound notebooks.

He looks at Bode.

Bode does not move.

BODE

Hers.

Kai looks to Eno.

She nods once.

He takes one.

Curved handwriting.

No columns.

Kai finds a date.

Looks across at Malik's ledger.

KAI

Same day.

Malik turns the ledger toward him.

Solomon:

WEST BINDING — REPLACED
RIVER +11 CM BRASS — CLEAN

The sister:

Insects stopped before the rain.

Below it:

Distance on the west path changed when I looked directly.

Kai reads the sentence twice.

Ade comes closer.

Kai turns several pages.

A later entry.
Tall form beyond the palm line.
One bend where a shoulder should be.
The next did not stay in the same place.
Kai stops.
His hand rises toward the back of his neck.
He catches it halfway.
Malik sees.
No one speaks.
Kai turns the page.
Then another.
The handwriting stops halfway down one sheet.
The rest of the notebook is blank.
Malik looks back to Solomon's ledger.
The dates continue.
Page after page.
Then, months later, beneath a column of measurements:
DISTANCE UNCERTAIN.
RE-MEASURE.
Malik reads it without moving his lips.
Across the table, Kai still holds the open notebook.
Ade reaches between them.
He rotates Solomon's ledger until both books face the same direction.
Same table.
Same light.
Malik's hand remains beside Solomon's knot diagram.
Kai's beside the line about the tall form.
Ade looks from one brother to the other.
Behind them, the inner door remains closed.
The anchored red network holds completely still across the dome.

CUT TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - MAINTENANCE ROOM - LATER

The two records remain open on the worktable.
Somewhere high above, carried down the staircase --
Children chase each other through the yard.

A radio changes stations.

Someone laughs hard enough to cough.

Life continuing in a house that does not know what it was built above.

Malik has made three stacks.

COMPLETED.

REPEATING.

UNREAD.

Ade watches him make a fourth.

ADE

What's that one?

MALIK

Trips.

ADE

Of course it is.

Passports. Receipts. Folded itineraries. Photocopied entry stamps tucked into ledgers.

Malik matches one trip to a maintenance date.

Then another.

Kai sits beneath the work lamp with his aunt's notebooks around him.

He is not reading them straight through.

Inside covers.

Back pages.

Loose inserts.

Anything addressed to someone.

Nothing.

Malik writes a date on scrap paper.

MALIK

Six times in four years.

KAI

Seven.

Kai holds up an old boarding stub from inside one of the notebooks.

KAI

This one isn't in his ledger.

Malik takes it.

Adds the date.

Ade studies the two of them working opposite ends of the same dead man.

ADE
This is a terrible family
vacation.

Nothing.

He lets the joke go.

Malik finds a ruled index.

BINDING MATERIALS.

BRASS.

WESTERN STONES.

RIVER LEVEL.

INNER FRAME.

He turns pages.

Stops.

A maintenance table.

Intervals measured in weeks and months.

Corrections in Solomon's hand.

The final completed line predates his death.

Below it --

future intervals.

Already ruled.

Already calculated.

Malik traces the next one.

MALIK
This is late.

Kai rises.

KAI
How late?

Malik checks the date again.

MALIK
Nine days.

The yard beyond the windows keeps going.

Kai looks toward the inner door.

KAI
Before we got here.

MALIK
After he died.

Kai studies the rows beneath it.

More dates.

KAI
He kept going.

Malik turns the page.

Materials.

Quantities.

Storage locations.

Key numbers.

Kai turns another page.

Blank.

Another.

Blank.

He checks the back cover.

Nothing.

KAI

Who does it?

Malik looks at him.

Kai flips to the index again.

KAI

There's no name.

He opens a drawer.

Red cotton bundles marked by weight.

KAI

Cloth.

Another drawer.

Keys with numbers stamped into paper tags.

KAI

Keys.

He finds a measurement sheet.

KAI

Three millimeters on a stone.

He looks at Malik.

KAI

But not a person.

Malik takes the half-open drawer before Kai can yank it farther.

MALIK

Slow down.

KAI

Where is the part for when he's dead?

MALIK

We haven't read everything.

KAI

He knew.

MALIK

Kai.

KAI

He knew he was dying.

Malik closes the drawer.

MALIK

I heard you.

KAI

Then stop looking for the folder
he forgot.

Malik holds his stare.

KAI

He didn't forget it.

Malik returns to the schedule.

MALIK

Something was due nine days ago.

KAI

By who?

MALIK

I don't know.

KAI

Exactly.

Ade reaches over.

Closes Solomon's ledger.

Then closes the sister's notebook.

Both brothers look at him.

ADE

You're both finishing his
sentence for him.

MALIK

I'm reading dates.

ADE

Then read the date.

To Kai --

ADE

And you read the blank page.

He puts the two closed books beside each other.

ADE

We don't know what he meant.

No one answers.

At the doorway --

Bode.

Behind him, Eno carries bread, fruit and water.

ENO

Breakfast has been waiting for
you since morning.

She sets the tray directly across Malik's stacks.

Malik moves the nearest papers away from the condensation.

Eno notices.

ENO

Good. Your hands still work.

She points at the food.

ENO

Use them.

Kai stays standing.

ENO

Kai.

He takes bread.

Bode enters.

Malik opens the ledger to the schedule.

MALIK

Did he talk about these dates?

Bode reads.

BODE

No.

MALIK

Ask you to continue them?

BODE

No.

KAI

Anyone?

Bode thinks.

BODE

Not that I know.

Malik taps the missed interval.

MALIK

What happens when it gets missed?

BODE

I don't know.

Kai absorbs the answer.

Eno hands him water.

KAI

He really left nothing.

Malik looks around the room.

MALIK

He left this.

KAI

That is not an instruction.

MALIK

I know.

Kai has no reply.

Eno looks from one brother to the other.

ENO

Solomon is not here.

She points up the stone steps, toward the voices in the house.

ENO

You are.

Malik looks at the schedule.

Then the inner door.

Then Kai.

MALIK

We don't touch the shrine.

KAI

And the brass?

MALIK

Stays where it is.

KAI

The inner door?

MALIK

No.

KAI

And if waiting is the problem?

MALIK

Then we find out what nine days ago was before we make another decision blind.

Kai looks at the missed date.

Then at Malik.

Ade takes the scrap with the missed date from Malik's hand.

Malik looks at him.

ADE

Not yours.

He puts it in the middle of the table.

ADE

Nobody goes anywhere alone.

Kai looks at him.

ADE

Nobody decides alone.

Malik considers the wording.

Then nods.

Kai takes longer.

Nods once.

Bode stays out of it.

Eno pushes the fruit toward Ade.

 ENO
Meeting finished?

 ADE
For now.

 ENO
Eat.

Ade takes a piece.

A small release.

Malik almost gives him a smile.

Kai looks toward the inner door.

The anchored red lines hold completely still across the dome.

He leaves it alone.

CUT TO:

EXT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - COURTYARD - NIGHT

The courtyard is the house's shared center.

On one side: the front veranda and family room, television bright inside.

On another: the kitchen door.

Between the kitchen wall and the older rear rooms, the BACK PASSAGE drops three shallow steps into the house toward the red-corded maintenance-room door.

Across the open yard, the compound gate leads away from the house.

No one is near the back passage tonight.

Dinner aftermath.

Plastic chairs.

Children underfoot.

A football match on television draws periodic SHOUTS from the front room.

Generator vibration beneath everything.

Mosquitoes worry bare ankles.

Eno directs plates from one hand to another without appearing to move.

Ade dries dishes beside the kitchen door.

ADE

I crossed an ocean to become
unpaid labor.

ENO

Then work. Nobody invited you to
stand there.

Ade goes back to the towel.

Kai sits in the courtyard with his camera resting in his
lap.

He is not looking through it.

Then --

METAL in his mouth.

He swallows.

It gets stronger.

His fingers tighten around the camera.

Across the courtyard, Malik sees his face change.

MALIK

Kai?

Kai looks at him.

KAI

Don't --

Pressure seals his ears.

The football crowd stretches into a thin electrical whine.

Then -- nothing.

The television still plays.

Men inside still react.

A cheer reaches Kai after the players have already reset.

He stands.

His body pitches hard left.

The courtyard does not.

He catches the chair.

Malik is already moving.

MALIK

Look at me.

Kai tries.

Malik's face will not become one face.

Two images overlap by half an inch.

Separate.

Rejoin.

KAI

It's here.

Ade sets the plate down.

Ade rises.

His balance drops out from under him.

He catches the table.

His palm stops six inches before the edge his eyes insist is there.

He freezes.

ADE

Malik.

No joke now.

The GENERATOR HUM disappears.

The bulb above them burns steadily.

No mosquitoes circle it.

Kai looks toward the mouth of the back passage.

MALIK

No.

Kai doesn't turn.

MALIK

Kai. Me.

Kai tries.

The descending passage behind Malik is empty.

STUTTER.

Empty back passage.

And something impossibly tall inside it.

No transition between the two.

Kai's knees strike tile.

He never feels himself fall.

His camera cracks against the floor.

MALIK

Kai!

Malik lunges.

STUTTER.

He is already beside him.

Momentum arrives afterward and nearly throws him past Kai.

Malik tries to inhale.

Nothing starts.

His chest is ready.

His body does not remember the next step.

He forces air out.

Drags one breath in.

Again.

Again.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - MAINTENANCE ROOM - SAME

Empty.

The empty dome receives no daylight.

One red load line draws tight from the inner-door frame to the WEST floor channel.

A copper guide complains against stone.

The line toward the river falls slack. The two forearm bands shift a fraction along their anchored guides.

The inner door does not move.

EXT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - COURTYARD - SAME

Ade takes one step toward his brothers.

His inner ear rotates the courtyard ninety degrees.

He drops to one hand.

A WOMAN carrying plates comes through the kitchen door and almost follows his line of sight toward the back passage.

Ade gets up before she can.

ADE

Kitchen. Please.

He takes the plates from her and turns her back toward the door.

She goes.

Kai is staring past Malik.

MALIK

Don't.

Kai's eyes flood.

A red capillary spreads across the white of his right eye.

STUTTER.

The Entity occupies the descending back passage.

Its height has nowhere to go.

One articulation folds beneath the ceiling.

Another begins behind plaster and finishes in open air.

STUTTER.

The arrangement changes.

The head occupies a position the neck cannot support.

STUTTER.

Closer.

No step.

Wood CREAKS somewhere down the back passage.
Dust lifts from the low ceiling --
hangs --
falls.

Kai's nose begins to bleed.

MALIK
Kai. Stop looking.

Kai tries to answer.

His tongue has gone numb.

KAI
I ca --

His mouth floods with saliva.
He turns and vomits onto the tile.

STUTTER.

A surface where a face might be tries to acquire depth.

STUTTER.

Almost human arrangement.

STUTTER.

Gone.

STUTTER.

There again.

The back-passage walls double.

The doorway doubles.

Malik doubles.

Kai doubles.

The Entity does not.

Ade sees enough.

A high tone drills through his ears.

Ade looks toward the front room.

Behind the veranda doors, family silhouettes move in
television light.

Nobody there is looking toward the back passage yet.

Ade forces himself upright.

Starts across the courtyard, putting his body between the
living house and the back-passage axis.

Blood begins running from his nose.

He wipes it with the back of his wrist and keeps moving.

At the back-passage mouth --

Malik grips Kai's face with both hands.

MALIK

Me.

Kai's eyes keep pulling sideways.

MALIK

Kai.

STUTTER.

Malik's hands are on him --

and Kai is six feet closer to the back passage.

STUTTER.

Back in Malik's hands.

Kai SCREAMS.

His right arm goes dead.

It drops against his body.

MALIK

Can you move it?

Kai tries.

Nothing.

Behind Malik --

one unresolved articulation occupies the same apparent space as Kai's shoulder.

No strike.

No impact.

Kai convulses.

Sensation returns all at once.

His fingers claw the tile.

Malik starts to turn.

KAI

DON'T.

Malik stops.

Inside the front room --

a chair scrapes.

Eno and Bode step onto the veranda.

Eyo behind them.

Their sightline crosses the courtyard toward Malik, Kai, and the mouth of the back passage beyond.

Ade reaches them.

ENO

Move.

Ade steps directly into Eno's line of sight.

ADE

Gas. Back of the house.

ENO

What?

ADE

Get everybody to the gate.

Eno sees the blood beneath his nose.

Looks once at Malik and Kai.

Then turns to the front room.

ENO

Eyo. Children first.

EYO

Come. Everybody move.

ENO

Gate. Now.

People spill from the front room onto the veranda.

They cross the open courtyard toward the gate, leaving the mouth of the back passage behind them on the opposite side.

A mother turns a child's face toward the gate.

The doubled edge of the back-passage mouth resolves to one.

Two men abandon the television and move after Eyo without looking back.

The wood down the passage releases with a soft tick.

The last of the children disappears behind the gate pillar.

Malik's next breath begins before he forces it.

Kai's two images of the courtyard pull closer together.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - MAINTENANCE ROOM - SAME

The anchored network eases.

Most lines recover their old bearing.

Not all.

The WEST line stays taut while the river line hangs without a return. One brass band remains an inch off its former resting mark.

The inner door remains closed.

EXT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - COURTYARD - SAME

STUTTER.

Entity.

STUTTER.

Empty back passage.

STUTTER.

Something impossibly far beyond the descending steps.

Then --

nothing.

Sound SLAMS back.

Generator.

Television crowd inside an empty front room.

A baby crying near the gate.

Plates clattering.

Insects.

Malik flinches from ordinary sound.

Kai curls around his right arm.

Ade presses one hand to his ear.

He looks toward the gate.

Family clustered there.

Safe enough for this second.

Eno steps halfway back into the courtyard but stops well short of the back passage.

ENO

Bring him here.

Ade returns to Kai.

He gets under one side.

Malik takes the other.

The three brothers cross the courtyard together, away from the house, toward the gate.

EXT. OKU FAMILY COMPOUND - BY THE GATE - MOMENTS LATER

The family gives them room without being asked.

Eno takes in the three brothers.

Kai's bloodshot eye.

Malik breathing through his nose, counting without numbers.

Ade wiping blood from his lip.

Eno looks at Ade.

He does not explain.

Eno looks back to the brothers.

ENO

Nobody goes near that back passage.

Then --

ENO

What happened?

No one answers.

Malik looks at Kai's hanging arm.

MALIK

Fingers.

Kai moves them.

Slow.

MALIK

Again.

Kai does.

The tremor remains.

Ade looks past them.

A BOY near the gate has leaned sideways, trying to see into the courtyard and toward the back passage.

Ade shifts one step.

Closes the sightline with his body.

Malik sees him do it.

Kai sees the boy.

Behind the brothers: the house.

In front of them: their family.

No one tells them where to stand.

They stay between the two.

CUT TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

EXT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT VERANDA - MORNING

Breakfast has moved outside.

Not ceremonially.

Nobody suggests taking plates deeper into the house.

Tea. Bread. Eggs. Fried plantain.

Conversation that starts and dies before becoming conversation.

The brothers look like men who slept without ever fully arriving at sleep.

Kai's right eye is webbed red. His right hand trembles when he lifts his cup.

His camera sits beside him. A crack runs through the casing from last night.

Malik inhales once through his nose before drinking, checking a sequence his body used to perform without permission.

Ade has cotton beneath one nostril. He removes it before a child can ask.

Eno sees all of it.

Bode eats quietly.

Eyo reaches for pepper.

The bowl is full.

Eno looks at it.

Then at the brothers.

ENO

Bode.

BODE

Hmm?

ENO

Market.

Bode looks at the full table.

BODE

For what?

ENO

Pepper. Tomatoes. Fish.

Eyo looks at the pepper bowl.

EYO

We have --

Eno looks at him.

EYO

We need pepper.

Ade almost smiles.

Eno points at the brothers with her chin.

ENO

Take them.

MALIK

We have work.

ENO

You have been looking at that passage since sunrise.

Malik does not deny it.

ENO

Go and look at pepper.

ADE

That's your solution?

ENO

You are alive enough to complain.
Good.

Kai looks toward the old house.

KAI

Crowds might be worse.

Malik looks at him.

MALIK

We don't know that.

ADE

We don't know staying here is better.

Bode wipes his hands.

BODE

We go. We come back.

He looks at all three.

BODE

Together.

Malik considers it.

Kai looks at his cracked camera.

His hand reaches toward it.

Stops.

He leaves it on the veranda.

CUT TO:

EXT. CALABAR MARKET - LATE MORNING

Bargaining.

Generators.

Fish smoke under corrugated shade.

Peppers piled in red and green mounds.

Fabric hanging above phone cases and plastic buckets.

A motorcycle horn trapped behind a handcart.

Two women argue over change and begin laughing before either one wins.

Bode moves through it without thinking about where his body should go.

The brothers do not.

Ade gets clipped by a basket and apologizes to the basket.

ADE

Sorry.

The WOMAN carrying it looks back.

WOMAN

Na basket you dey beg?

ADE

It looked offended.

She laughs and keeps moving.

Bode buys tomatoes.

A VENDOR adds one more than he asked for.

BODE

I said six.

VENDOR

This one small.

BODE

Then it should cost small.

The vendor waves him away, smiling.

For several minutes, nothing is wrong.

Malik carries two bags because nobody stopped him early enough.

Ade tastes a piece of fruit he did not intend to buy.

Kai reaches toward his chest when a burst of color crosses the lane.

No camera there.

His hand closes on his shirt instead.

Ahead --

DRUMS.

Not the earth-borne pressure from the shrine.

Real drums.

Human hands.

A MASQUERADE PROCESSION moves into the market lane with attendants and musicians.

Vendors make room without panic.

Children climb onto low walls.

People grin, call to one another, keep selling around the edges.

An attendant exchanges a familiar greeting with Bode as the procession approaches.

Bode answers and steps aside.

The brothers follow his lead.

Ade watches the movement.

For the first time this morning, some life reaches his face.

Kai watches too.

Then --

METAL.

Faint.

Back of his tongue.

His smile never arrives.

Malik sees him swallow.

MALIK

Kai.

Kai keeps his eyes on the ground between them.

KAI

I know.

Ade hears that.

The festive drums continue.

One strike reaches Ade twice.

The second arrives after the drummer's hand has already lifted for the next beat.

Ade presses two fingers beneath his ear.

BODE

What?

ADE

Nothing.

He knows it is not nothing.

The procession crosses their lane.

Bright movement fills the space between bodies.

For one instant, two masquerade figures overlap in Kai's peripheral vision.

Between them --

A VERTICAL INTERRUPTION where no performer stands.

Too tall for the awning.

Kai looks up before he can stop himself.

STUTTER.

Masquerade cloth crossing foreground.

Behind it, an articulation bends where the market lane has no room for it.

STUTTER.

Only stalls.

STUTTER.

The procession keeps its rhythm.

Something behind it does not.

Kai drops his gaze.

His right hand starts shaking harder.

KAI

Don't let me look.

Malik steps directly into his sightline.

Not touching him yet.

MALIK

Me.

Kai fixes on Malik.

A group of shoppers crosses between them.

For half a second Malik cannot see Kai.

They clear.

Kai is farther away than the space they crossed should allow.

Malik's diaphragm misses one automatic breath.

He catches Ade's sleeve.

MALIK

Kai.

Ade already sees him.

He takes Malik's wrist and keeps it.

ADE

Don't chase the gap.

Malik looks at him.

Ade points with his chin to Kai's actual body.

They move together.

The crowd continues around them.

Nobody screams.

Nobody else appears sick.

Ade watches a woman count money into a vendor's palm.

STUTTER.

For Ade, the exchange is already finished -- the notes in the vendor's hand.

STUTTER.

His vision catches the release again -- the same notes leaving her fingers.

The woman never breaks rhythm.

Ade does.

His face empties.

The market has too many bodies to verify one at a time.

Bode reaches Kai first.

BODE

Kai.

Kai looks at Bode's shirt, not his face.

BODE

What happened?

Kai cannot answer without looking past him.

He does not.

The procession moves farther down the lane.

The drums should be receding.

One beat lands inside Malik's chest at full volume.

He flinches.

Ade looks back despite himself.

Between two moving bodies --

STUTTER.

The Entity resolves in the gap between them.

Not wearing a mask.

Not part of the procession.

The performers cross the same patch of lane. Nothing in their movement acknowledges what Ade sees.

STUTTER.

Gone.

ADE

Bode.

Bode looks at him.

ADE

Move us.

No explanation.

Bode does not ask for one.

He takes the shortest route he knows.

EXT. MARKET SIDE LANE - CONTINUOUS

Bode cuts through a narrow lane between fabric stalls and a row of locked metal shutters.

Malik keeps one hand on Kai's shoulder.

Ade keeps hold of Malik's wrist until there is room to walk side by side.

Nobody runs.

Their bodies want to.

Kai starts to turn toward the drums.

Malik's hand tightens on his shoulder.

Kai stops himself.

Ade hears another beat behind them.

He keeps his eyes forward.

They round the shutters. The procession drops out of sight.

The market noise continues behind them.

The metallic taste remains.

For several steps, nothing improves.
 Then Kai's hand tremor begins to ease.
 Ade's doubled drumbeat becomes one rhythm again.
 Malik takes a breath without checking it first.
 They stop beneath the shade of a closed awning.
 Bode looks at all three.

BODE

What did you see?

No one answers immediately.
 Malik looks back toward the market entrance.
 Then in the opposite direction -- toward where the house
 would be, far beyond buildings and traffic.

MALIK

We left the house.

Kai finally looks at him.
 Ade releases Malik's wrist.
 Behind them, the market keeps going.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT VERANDA - EARLY AFTERNOON

The market bags arrive before anybody explains the faces
 carrying them.
 Bode sets tomatoes, pepper and fish on the veranda table.
 Eno looks at Kai's shaking hand. The dried blood at Ade's
 nostril. Malik taking one extra breath through his nose.

ENO

You found pepper.

BODE

Yes.

ENO

What else?

Kai answers before Bode has to lie.

KAI

It happened there.

Eno looks across the ordinary daylight of her courtyard.

ENO

Yesterday the house. Today the
 market.

ADE

We're covering ground.

The joke has nowhere to go. Ade lets it die.

ENO

You said something was late.

MALIK

Nine days.

ENO

Then find out what was due. I did
not say fix anything.

Malik waits for both brothers.

MALIK

Room only.

KAI

Room only.

ADE

Together.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BACK PASSAGE - MOMENTS LATER

Bode loosens the ordinary outer red hitch by hand. Unlocks
the door.

The stone staircase drops beyond the reach of daylight.

MALIK

If one of us wants out, we go.

KAI

One of us.

MALIK

One of us.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

One shaded work lamp. The old dome overhead. The
maintained inner door centered across the room.

The red lines remain anchored at both ends. One runs hard
against the WEST guide. The river return hangs loose. An
open brass forearm band has shifted along its guide.

Malik reaches toward it. Stops himself.

MALIK

Nobody touches anything.

He opens Solomon's ledger on the curved worktable.

Three earlier dates. CHECKED. MEASURED. One followed by
WEST BINDING -- REPLACED. Another by nothing.

KAI

The date told him when to look.

MALIK

Not what he'd find.

ADE

So we're nine days late looking.

Malik writes on the back of a market receipt: WESTERN
STONES. RIVER LEVEL. INNER FRAME? BRASS?

KAI

The broken half.

Malik looks toward the stairs. Then around the room: brass guides, brass bands, dozens of fittings.

MALIK

Maybe. We don't guess.

ADE

Measure. Don't repair.

BODE

The western service track still comes close. My truck can reach the pump clearing, not the ravine.

At the top of the stairs, Eno waits without entering.

ENO

Today?

Malik studies his brothers' faces.

ENO

Tomorrow will still be late.

She leaves him no clean answer.

EXT. WESTERN SERVICE TRACK - LATE AFTERNOON

Bode's aging pickup stops at a locked irrigation gate. Beyond it, an old pump clearing and the maintained footpath toward the western stones.

The truck cannot fit farther. The distance to the hidden ravine remains real.

Eno has packed water, clean cloth, salt crackers and a folded kitchen towel. Ade distributes them without ceremony.

ADE

Five-star family excursion.

Kai takes the towel. His right hand cannot quite fold it.

Malik checks his breathing before he starts walking. Notices Kai noticing. Does not pretend.

EXT. WESTERN BOUNDARY PATH - LATER

Bode keeps to the path. The brothers follow.

The first boundary stone wears three layers of red binding. Beneath them, a much older copper line disappears underground toward the house.

Malik compares Solomon's map to the angle of the stone.

MALIK

He corrected the same bearing six times.

ADE

Because it kept moving?

MALIK

Because he kept pulling it back.

The latest red binding has cut a pale groove into the stone. Under it, two older loops have been drawn until they cannot be opened.

At the next stone, the same. Then the next.

Not careless work. Frightened work repeated until there is no movement left in it.

Kai photographs the grooves rather than the forest.

At the ravine overlook, he stops.

Below, through roots: the hidden shrine. The remaining half of the brass fitting still sits in its recess.

A small tremor travels through the seated half. Brass dust falls outward onto the lip.

KAI

It broke before I touched it.

MALIK

And you still took it.

KAI

Yes.

No absolution in either answer.

The water gathered inside a root hollow shivers into sharp, crowded lines. A bruised blue-black edge passes over its surface.

Kai raises his camera.

A LOW, SERRATED NOTE presses against his teeth.

He lowers the lens before it finds anything beyond the water.

ADE

Kai.

KAI

I'm looking at the water.

Farther down the path, a rusted brass service plate carries two shallow channels. IN. RETURN. No mystic inscription. A working diagram almost worn away by hands.

Malik photographs it.

Bode moves toward a closer drop.

MALIK

No. The path.

Bode stops. This time the sons hold the limit.

EXT. PUMP CLEARING - SUNSET

Kai sits on the pickup tailgate. Water trembles in an enamel cup between his knees.

The sharp pattern subsides.

A slower, rounded pulse follows it. The water organizes into a single expanding ring.

Kai stares at the difference.

From the road beyond the gate, the rest of Calabar continues without them.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - EVENING

Eno changes the cloth beneath the broken brass half without handling it. The old Vancouver carving remains separately wrapped in Kai's camera bag.

Malik lays out the photographs of the western stones.

ENO

He tightened every one himself.

MALIK

You saw him?

ENO

I washed what it did to his arms.

She places a basin of water on the table. Not an answer they had thought to ask for.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - NIGHT

The brothers enter together. Bode remains near the stair. Eno remains upstairs with the family.

On the oldest map, copper routes leave the centered inner door and converge on a worn circle in the floor.

At the circle's center: the stain.

Malik compares the IN and RETURN service plate photograph to two brass guides.

MALIK

Same channels.

He steps to the worn center only after Kai and Ade nod.

The two open brass bands slide along their anchored guide lines.

Not thrown. Not alive. Drawn into position by the loaded geometry of the room.

They close around Malik's forearms with two soft, precise clicks.

Malik feels a pressure in his right shoulder. The WEST line tightens. His left wrist receives a colder answering pull from the river bearing.

His breath catches.

ADE

Say the word.

MALIK

I'm here.

Kai watches an enamel water cup on the worktable. One faint rounded ring.

Malik eases his right arm outward an inch. The WEST guide releases a little copper dust. The river line takes the slack.

On the room's old diagram, a mark that had been hidden by Solomon's newer pencil corrections becomes visible.

MALIK

It isn't a lock.

Kai studies the routes.

KAI

It's carrying something.

Ade stands beside Malik without touching either band.

ADE

Can you get out?

Malik returns both arms to the resting marks. The bands open.

They slide back to their fixed guides.

The skin beneath each band bears a red crescent.

Bode looks at the crescents. Looks away before anybody can see why.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT ROOM - LATER

Eno brings down an ordinary cardboard box from the top of a cupboard.

ENO

He told me to throw it out.

ADE

And?

ENO

I do not take disposal
instructions from frightened men.

Inside: faded dance-hall handbills. A cassette with SOLOMON scratched into the plastic. Photographs that have not been mutilated.

In one, a very young Solomon stands behind a rented turntable, headphones crooked, laughing so hard his face is almost unrecognizable.

Ade looks at the photograph. Then at the stern man on the funeral programme.

ADE

Who is that?

BODE

Your father before he started
arriving everywhere early.

Kai finds another photograph. Their aunt at the worktable, ink on one thumb, eating a slice of orange over a spread of charts. Solomon's hand enters the frame holding the other half.

Her face is turned toward whoever took the picture. Not a symbol. A person interrupted at lunch.

BODE

She hated when he put the peel on her pages.

MALIK

Where were you when she died?

Bode takes time.

BODE

Outside town with our uncle.

ADE

And Dad?

BODE

Playing music. He was supposed to come back.

The cassette case opens. Tucked inside: a dance-hall receipt dated the same night as a clipped district clinic record.

Malik notices the times. He does not say them aloud.

KAI

Did he get there?

BODE

After.

Bode studies the photograph of his sister with the orange.

BODE

He never played another record where I could hear it.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Eno sets rice before the brothers.

Kai manages three bites. The fourth brings a metallic taste and sudden nausea. He reaches the sink in time.

Ade steadies him with one hand, the other pressed below his own ear.

Malik rubs the red marks on his forearms. Stops when Eno sees.

ENO

Eat what you can. Pain does not become wisdom because you hide it.

Malik takes one bite.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - NEXT MORNING

The Vancouver carving lies on clean cloth at one end of the worktable.

The active shrine half lies on separate cloth at the other.

Two objects. Related lines. Different hollow treatments.
The old carving's rear face bears a heat-darkened crack
and worn mounting scars.

Malik finds a dated materials entry after the clinic
record.

ORIGINAL REMOVED. NEW CENTER SET. WEST RETURN HELD.

The new entry is Solomon's handwriting. Beneath it, his
sister's older, rounder annotation survives on the
preceding page.

Leave enough play for the rain.

ADE

He replaced hers.

KAI

He replaced theirs.

Kai turns the old carving over. A small nick matches the
brass silhouette in the old veranda photograph.

MALIK

And carried it all the way to
Vancouver.

ADE

He couldn't leave it. Couldn't
tell us why.

Nobody turns the old carving into an answer for the broken
shrine. Malik wraps it separately again.

On Kai's shrine photograph, the fracture runs through the
active component's center. Fresh brass dust lies on the
outer lip.

Kai zooms closer. The wood cover was bowed outward before
he broke its red thread.

KAI

Something was already pushing.

MALIK

From which side?

Kai cannot answer.

From beneath the inner door: one low, rough vibration.

Not the slower pulse from the pump clearing.

The WEST line pulls taut.

The cup on the table breaks into crowded, jagged ripples.

Ade backs away from the central circle.

ADE

We're done for now.

For once Malik does not argue.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT VERANDA - AFTERNOON

Kai plays the footage from the shrine without looking at its darkest frames.

On the camera screen: the root hollow. Water under broken leaves. Jagged lines running toward the recess.

A moment later, farther back in the image: one slow circular ring.

Kai isolates the two sounds by listening, not explaining. First, the low serrated pressure.

Then the rounded note underneath it.

KAI

Listen to which one comes first.

Ade hears it. Malik does not want to.

MALIK

One sound can change.

KAI

Not while the first one's still there.

In an old notebook, their aunt drew the familiar impossible silhouette in charcoal. Tall. Articulated incorrectly. Beside it, a water bowl rendered as concentric, even rings.

On the following page, only a violent field of short diagonal strokes against a closed boundary mark.

No second anatomy. No monster catalog.

Two different disturbances sharing one page.

ADE

The one we saw.

KAI

It might not be what started this.

The air changes before anyone can improve the sentence.

The water in Eno's drinking glass develops sharp, close ripples. A bruise of dark violet touches the reflection of the brass rim.

Then a faint old-gold line appears in the reflection from the back passage.

Rounded rings meet the jagged pattern. Neither wins.

Kai's right eye reddens again. Malik forgets the start of a breath. Ade grips the veranda rail as his balance folds sideways.

ENO

Inside. Not you three. Everybody else.

She redirects the younger relatives toward the front gate without looking down the passage.

Bode opens the gate. Counts people as they leave.

The two rhythms separate.

Kai wipes blood from the corner of his eye.

KAI

There are two.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - LATE AFTERNOON

The three brothers choose to descend. Bode stays at the top, holding a first-aid box. No family member enters the back passage.

The WEST line vibrates hard enough to raise copper grit from its guide. The river return hangs slack.

Malik takes the central working position.

The two brass bands seat around his already bruised forearms.

MALIK

Read the water.

Kai turns his face from the inner door. Watches the enamel cup instead.

Jagged ripples.

KAI

Right side. Too much.

Malik eases the western guide. A sliver of tension transfers through his shoulders.

Then the serrated pressure strikes again.

An anchored line drops from the dome onto the guide across Malik's left shoulder. Another tightens around his ribs.

The room does not choose him. It recruits the only closed working circuit it has.

Malik's fingers go numb around the central index.

ADE

Let go.

MALIK

I can't.

Ade grabs Malik's arm and pulls against the incoming load.

The pressure finds a dead end.

A brutal release throws Ade sideways into the curved stone wall.

His shoulder hits first. Then his ribs. Air leaves him in one thin cry.

Kai turns toward him. The room doubles. He vomits beside the worktable.

The slower rounded pulse enters beneath the rough one.
 For an instant, the maintained inner door stands against a
 depth greater than the chamber can hold.
 No one sees another world. Only the unbearable wrongness
 of a threshold under too much relation.

KAI

Malik. The river.

Malik forces his left wrist toward the slack return guide.
 The line takes enough load to open one band.
 He falls to his knees.

The shoulder line returns along its fixed track. The door
 remains shut.

Ade tries to stand. His right arm will not lift above his
 ribs.

Bode reaches the lower stair but does not enter the
 working circle.

BODE

I'm here.

Malik crawls to Ade using hands that barely close.

MALIK

I'm sorry.

ADE

Try being sorry slower.

He cannot finish the smile.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - EVENING

Eno straps Ade's arm against his body with a folded cloth.
 Each breath costs him.

She cleans the circular abrasions on Malik's forearms. One
 finger remains without feeling.

Kai rinses his mouth. The red in his right eye has
 widened.

ENO

No one goes down again until you
 know what happened to her.

No one claims the family can simply leave everyone else
 inside the pressure's reach.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT ROOM - NIGHT

Eno lays out the clipped district clinic record, old
 notebooks, the uncut family photograph and the retired
 brass carving.

Her hand remains on the photograph.

ENO

She was not the worst thing that
 happened to her.

Kai turns through the aunt's ordinary entries.

A reminder to buy oranges. A complaint about Solomon returning a borrowed record scratched. A neat sketch of the river after rain.

At the back: a page torn away. The next leaf appears blank.

Malik angles the work lamp so Kai does not have to stare directly at the page.

His camera catches indentations the eye misses.

Kai does not invent missing words. He shifts the angle until the pressure marks emerge.

S -- IT WAS NOT THE ONE AT THE DOOR.

IT CAME AFTER.

The last stroke digs into the paper beneath.

An unfinished line below it: OPEN THE RET--

ADE

She wrote to him.

BODE

He never got it.

Bode's voice catches on the smallest fact, not the grandest one.

BODE

He kept looking in the wrong pages.

Malik finds the diagram of the service plate. IN. RETURN.

Solomon's later annotations cover the return path with years of added reinforcement.

The aunt's older line remains visible beneath his pencil.

No entry without an exit.

Ade touches his injured shoulder.

ADE

I pulled him shut.

KAI

You didn't know.

ADE

Neither did she. Not alone.

In the next room, the wrapped old carving and broken shrine half remain on separate cloths.

Nothing has changed custody because a revelation needed it to.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - LATER

The clinic record is brief. Extensive circumferential compression. Traction injuries. Severe oxygen deprivation. Red fiber embedded beneath both wrists.

No occult language. No impossible medical certainty.

Below the report, a collection time.

The dance-hall receipt puts Solomon across town when the first injury was documented.

His next ledger entry begins in the middle of a sentence. Pencil pressed hard enough to tear the page.

HELD WEST. SET NEW CENTER. RIVER CLOSED.

For years afterward: additional bindings, smaller intervals, fewer open return marks.

MALIK

He thought holding harder meant
nobody else would die.

ADE

And nobody else would have to
know.

Kai looks at the impression from the missing page.

KAI

She was trying to tell him the
thing at the door came after the
other pressure.

MALIK

Two directions. One person.

Eno takes the clinical record away when it has done its work.

ENO

Enough of how she died.

She places the orange photograph back in the middle of the table.

ENO

Remember who had to live with it.

Bode looks at his brother's laughing photograph.

BODE

He felt it from town. Ran all the
way back. By then there was
nothing left he could carry for
her.

Ade looks toward the chamber stairs. One arm held tight against his side.

ADE

We don't go in there one at a
time.

Malik studies the return diagram.

MALIK

We don't make one person into the
room.

Outside, every insect in the courtyard stops at once.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BACK PASSAGE - NIGHT

Eno moves the last relatives out through the front. Bode carries her first-aid box and the pickup keys.

The outer red cord has pulled so tight that its ordinary hitch begins to bite into the hook.

Ade steadies the hook with his good hand. Malik loosens the loop instead of cutting it.

The passage exhales cold, stale air.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The inner door stays physically closed.

Its old-gold threshold line is barely visible beneath layers of Solomon's overdrawn reinforcement.

The copper return channel toward the river has been blocked by an ordinary brass stop, tightened and retightened until the edges are polished.

Malik finds matching entries across thirteen years.

RETURN HELD.

RETURN HELD.

RETURN HELD.

KAI

He could keep it steady alone
like that.

MALIK

Until something needed to pass
through.

Ade tries to reach the stop. His injured shoulder refuses the movement. He changes angle and uses his good hand instead.

A faint rounded pulse crosses the water in the enamel cup.

The harsh rhythm answers from the WEST line.

Kai does not look at the door. The camera screen, angled toward the cup, becomes his indirect line of sight.

In its reflection, a dark bruised edge pushes inward from the western bearing.

A pale bone-gold response gathers at the maintained threshold.

KAI

The dark one pushes. The other
one answers.

MALIK

If we open the return?

KAI

We give the pressure somewhere to
go.

The WEST line drives tight enough to crack its copper guide.

Above them, the house lets out the low complaint of an old beam taking too much weight.

Bode calls down from the staircase.

BODE (O.S.)

Everyone is out.

Another strike answers from beneath the land.

The shrine remains broken. The chamber can no longer wait for a cleaner plan.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The first impact is not a creature.

It is pressure from the wrong bearing.

The WEST line becomes a red bar. Copper grit lifts from the floor channels. In the water cup, every ripple cuts toward the center.

The dark-violet bruise remains only in water and tarnished metal.

Malik steps into the working circle by choice.

The brass bands close over his existing abrasions.

He bites down on the pain and sets both feet against the stone.

MALIK

Kai.

Kai braces the camera against the worktable with both shaking hands.

KAI

West coming in. River still closed.

Ade works at the brass return stop with his good arm. Every turn pulls at the injury along his ribs.

The serrated pressure hits again.

Three anchored lines travel along their fixed guides toward Malik's loaded position.

One catches his shoulder. One draws across his ribs. The third fixes his left ankle to the river bearing.

His body is pulled in three directions at once.

The stain beneath him darkens where sweat falls into the porous stone.

His aunt's death exists in the room without showing her again.

KAI

Ade. Now.

Ade gets one turn out of the return stop.

The maintained inner door releases half an inch.

Beyond it: a narrow physical antechamber. Old stone. Another closed outer boundary impossible to place at a useful distance.

For one breath, the familiar impossible silhouette resolves in the controlled threshold between those surfaces.

Too tall. Wrongly articulated. Ancient and unreadable.

It does not reach for Malik.

The slower rounded pressure enters the chamber.

The two rhythms occupy the same water.

Jagged violet-black cuts. Wide old-gold circles. Red load lines carrying the collision through living bodies.

The geometry of the chamber seems to tip. Not the floor itself. The brothers' ability to agree where it is.

Kai's right eye fills red. Blood leaves one nostril. He vomits and keeps the camera aimed at the cup.

Ade's injured shoulder buckles. He nearly falls against the return stop.

Malik tries to breathe.

His chest cannot complete the next instruction.

The rib line tightens.

MALIK

Don't -- touch -- me.

Ade remembers the first correction. His own body thrown against stone. A dead end.

He does not grab Malik.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PRESSURE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Ade follows the return line with his eyes.

From Malik's left wrist. Across a copper guide. Through the brass stop. Toward the river channel in the floor.

The line has an entrance.

It has no exit.

ADE

Malik.

Malik's hands have gone pale inside the bands. His left fingers cannot close.

Ade puts his good arm beneath the anchored return line. With his injured side, he forces the brass stop open another fraction.

He makes himself part of the route, not a wall across it.

ADE

Give me one side.

Malik hears Bode at the funeral without the film showing it again.

His first instinct is to keep all the weight.

He loosens his left grip.

The pressure moves into Ade.

His injured ribs seize. Blood runs from his nose. He lets the line travel over his forearm and out toward the open river guide.

ADE

Don't hold it. Let it through.

The shoulder line on Malik loses enough tension for one arm to move.

Kai watches only the reflected water.

The dark pattern forces inward from WEST. The slower gold rings answer from the threshold.

Between them, the old center index remains turned toward Solomon's closed bearing.

KAI

Center. Not west. The middle.

Malik reaches with two numb fingers.

Misses.

The inner door opens another breath's width.

The familiar form becomes almost coherent.

No one looks directly at it.

Kai loses his balance. His shoulder strikes the worktable. The enamel cup begins to fall.

He catches it against his chest. Water spills down his shirt. Enough remains to read.

KAI

Again.

Ade's good arm shakes beneath the moving return load.

ADE

I have this side.

Malik releases the instinct to hold both.

He rotates the center index one measured quarter turn.

The return channel opens.

The chamber takes a breath through all three of them.

The rough pressure drives hard once more against the western line.

The rounded answering pulse does not strike it like a weapon. It restores the line between the controlled threshold and what has no right to enter it.

In the enamel cup, the jagged violet cuts are pressed outward to the rim.

The dark reflection vanishes beneath the lip.

The old-gold ring widens once.

The familiar silhouette recedes into the antechamber without becoming human, grateful or safe.

The inner door settles closed.

The red lines release along their fixed guides.

Ade hits the floor on his uninjured side.

Kai drops beside the worktable, retching without anything left to bring up.

The brass bands open.

Malik collapses across the old stain.

For one unbearable moment, his chest does not move.

Ade drags himself across the stone with one arm.

ADE

Malik.

No response.

Kai reaches Malik's face with a shaking hand.

KAI

Malik.

One ragged breath begins.

Then another.

Above them, Bode starts down the stair but stops at the edge of the chamber, waiting for them to call him in.

BODE

Tell me.

Ade looks at his brothers. At the lines now carrying a slow, even load.

ADE

We're here.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - PRE-DAWN

Eno cleans blood from Kai's cheek. His hand still shakes too badly to hold the cloth.

She secures Ade's arm against his chest again. Every knot leaves a loop that can be loosened.

Malik sits bent over his own breathing. Red welts cross his forearms and ribs. Two fingers remain numb.

The broken brass half rests beneath its ordinary kitchen cloth.

The retired Vancouver carving remains wrapped inside Kai's camera bag. It will not be used as a substitute.

KAI

The other half is still there.

MALIK

Then we're not finished.

Eno looks at what the room has done to each of them.

ENO

You do not walk there like this.

Bode sets the pickup keys on the table.

BODE

The pump clearing. After that,
the path.

Eno brings clean red cotton from Solomon's carefully
labeled materials. She places it beside the broken half.

ENO

Bring everybody back.

EXT. WESTERN SERVICE TRACK - DAWN

Bode drives slowly enough that every rut can be seen
before it reaches them.

Ade rides in front, his shoulder bound. Kai braces the
wrapped brass half between both palms. Malik sits beside
him, unable to make a fist.

No one is suddenly well.

At the irrigation gate, Bode stops. He remains with the
truck.

The brothers take the maintained footpath beyond the pump
clearing together.

EXT. WESTERN BOUNDARY PATH - CONTINUOUS

The over-tight red loops still bite into the stones. The
work after this morning will not repair itself.

Ade leans on Malik with the side that does not hurt as
badly. Malik accepts his weight without trying to carry
all of it. Kai stops twice to steady the world.

They reach the ravine by the established path. No
impossible shortcut.

EXT. HIDDEN SHRINE - DAWN

The remaining half waits in the recess.

Kai unwraps its missing piece. His fingers shake. Malik
steadies his wrist without taking the brass away.

Ade supports the old wooden cover against his good
shoulder.

Kai aligns the fracture.

The halves meet. Still cracked. No miraculous repair. The
original fitting is seated and held in its working place
again.

Malik guides the clean red cotton around the cover with fingers that can barely feel it.

Ade catches the other end.

Kai shows them the old loop from his first photograph.

Together, they tie a binding that holds -- and can still be opened.

Nothing announces approval.

One insect resumes.

Then another.

Water moves somewhere beyond the trees.

Malik lets go of the knot first.

Ade keeps his hand beneath Malik's for one more breath.

Kai closes his camera bag around the old carving.

Three brothers stand before the same broken thing, no longer making one body carry all of it.

They turn toward the path home together.

FADE OUT.